isation) in the states. In this context, the Palakkad *baithak* discussed deputation to the BJP. As for the BJP's state unit chiefs, they have already got new faces in Haryana, Bihar and Rajasthan, in line with the parent organisation's wishes. It is likely that at least half of all state units will have new chiefs by January next year, the priority being Karnataka, Telangana, Punjab, Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh. The BJP flagged off its countrywide membership renewal programme on September 2, with Nadda handing over a membership certificate card to PM Modi. This is the first step to building a quorum to elect Nadda's successor. Critics say the fact that the BJP hasn't been able to name a new party chief, or even a working president, reflects the churn within.

In the past decade, the BJP has mastered the art of turning even assembly polls into Modi vs others battles. The double-engine government plank worked in many places, with the BJP's army, manned by the RSS *swayamsevak*s (volunteers), managing things on the ground. The Lok Sabha election results, though, indicate that the brand may have been seriously impaired. As a Sangh leader points out, the efficacy is there, but the "vigour has withered". In the coming polls, the BJP will be testing the brand again, for both sides know PM Modi is still their best bet. The Sangh, though, wants "wider consultations" before tickets are announced.

TURBULENCE IN UP

Since the Lok Sabha results, voices of dissent in the heartland states have only got louder. The schisms in various state units and the poor implementation of flagship schemes have exposed the chinks in the BJP's otherwise formidable election armour. In Uttar Pradesh, where the BJP's Lok Sabha seats dropped from 62 to 33 out of 80, deputy CM Keshav Prasad Maurya dropped a cryptic and combative post on X in July: "The organisation is bigger than the government, the pain of the workers is my pain. No one is bigger than the organisation, the workers are the pride." The attack was clearly directed at CM Yogi Adityanath and his handling of the Lok Sabha campaign, hinting that the leadership had let down the workers. Fellow deputy CM Brajesh Pathak, too, has expressed his dissatisfaction many a time. Several other state BJP leaders, including a few who lost the Lok Sabha election, echo the sentiments in private. Many are also asking whether Yogi's 'bulldozer baba' image is backfiring on the party in the state. Even the building of the Ram temple does not seem to have helped, for the BJP lost not just in Faizabad (which includes Ayodhya) but also in the neighbouring constituencies. The Lok Sabha election results also exposed the limitations of polarisation. In fact, some analysts say all the '*char sau paar*' talk prodded a consolidation of the anti-BJP vote among the Muslims and Dalits, in the fear that a super majority for the party would be to their detriment. In the absence of the active participation of RSS volunteers, that narrative wasn't countered effectively. Ironically, Yogi's supporters had complained after the drastic losses that the high command had ignored his advice on axing several sitting MPs.



UNITED FACE? (From right) UP CM Yogi Adityanath with deputies Keshav Prasad Maurya and Brajesh Pathak in Lucknow, Jul. 29

THE SANGH FEELS YOGI IS STILL THEIR BEST BET IN UP, ESPECIALLY WITH HIS PAN-INDIA APPEAL AS A HINDUTVA CHAMPION. SOURCES SAY A TRUCE HAS BEEN DECLARED FOR NOW

The CM's immediate concern, though, are the bypolls in 10 assembly seats (only five of which were with the BJP). He has deployed a team of 30 ministers to oversee the poll preparations, but has again kept deputies Maurya and Pathak out. In July end, Maurya and state unit chief Bhupendra Chaudhary had separate hour-long meetings with party chief Nadda to resolve the crisis. This is clearly not a happy situation for the BJP brass in Delhi, especially in a state that has been the party's original Hindutva laboratory. The Sangh still feels that Yogi remains their strongest card in UP, especially with his pan-India appeal as a Hindutva champion. Sources say a truce has been declared till the byelections are over.

THE ASSEMBLY POLL WOES

In poll-bound Maharashtra, Haryana and Jharkhand, the BJP is facing severe headwinds. In Maharashtra, the BJP's Mahayuti coalition is on shaky ground after the Lok Sabha results, which saw the Opposition Maha Vikas Aghadi alliance walk away with 31 of the state's 48 seats. What once seemed like a masterstroke—dividing the two big regional parties, the Shiv Sena and the Nationalist Congress party (NCP)—and running a Mahayuti coalition government with the splinter